

BENGAL SCAM

BLACKEST OF BOARDS

By Romita Datta

Around 30,000 vacancies in state-run schools—for the youth of employment-parched West Bengal, it was a once-in-a-decade opportunity. However, for the thousands of diligent candidates who took the State Level Selection Test (SLST), that modest ambition curdled into bitter disappointment. The reason? They were left in the lurch even as many allegedly 'ineligible' candidates made it to the merit list and secured jobs. Soon enough, there were malodorous whiffs of alleged political patronage and the sale of posts. All such allegations of irregularities were denied by the ruling Trinamool Congress government. For some 4,000 graduates and post-graduates caught in a limbo, there was nothing for it but to file petitions in courts, and as it slow-cooked there, sit in a dharna in central Kolkata.

They endured police batons, arrests, insults and tragedy—two protesters took their own lives and two others died of ill health. Sensing a scandal, the state government approached with inducements, but little ground was ceded. The breakthrough came on February 28, 2022, when a Calcutta High Court single-judge bench of Justice Abhijit Gangopadhyay ordered a Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) probe into the alleged irregularities. Then, on May 5, the government gave in—it announced the creation of 5,000 additional teaching posts to accommodate the protesters.

Government teachers are recruited by the School Service Commission (SSC) through the SLST. Soon after the recruitment process started in 2017 following the exam (500,000 candidates took it), as many as 2,030 petitioners approached the Calcutta High Court, alleging various discrepancies. The protracted litigation has unearthed nearly 6,200 instances of alleged deviation from due process.

Instead of the usual practice of publishing full results on the website, candidates had to feed their names and roll numbers in a portal. The cryptic signal that told them they had qualified and were eligible for the interview read: "Called for verification" (of documents). "Since there was no list of successful candidates, there was no way to find out who was being called for the interview and getting appointment letters. We sensed a hidden agenda," says Mohidul Islam, president of the Yuva-Chhatra Adhikar Mancha (Rights Forum for Youths and Students).

Some students went on a hunger strike for 29 days, demanding full results with marks and ranks; some moved court. Under orders from the HC, the SSC produced a printed list in January 2019, which was equally incomplete—a list of names, roll numbers and ranks, without marks. A waiting list was also published. The continuing absence of marks increased the suspicion that many unsuccessful candidates had been called for the interview. Plus, candidates way down in the waiting list allegedly jumped ranks.